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The Oil Manual | Europe

SPR Tracker: How Much Has Been Released? What's Next?

Strategic oil reserves have played a key role in absorbing the recent supply shock. However, data on SPR releases is dispersed and often hard-to-track, especially outside the US. In this short note, we pull all relevant data points together into an easy-to-digest overview.

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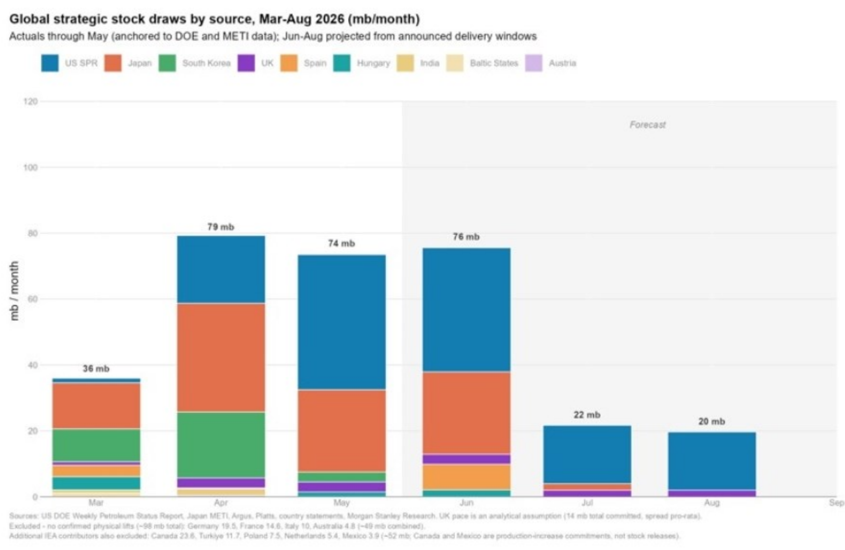
Key Takeaways

- IEA member countries announced 400 mb of SPR releases, later raised to 426 mb. So far, we track ~150 mb of actual releases, running at 2.5 mb/d across Apr-Jun.
- US and Japan dominate with 133 mb contracted and 99 mb committed respectively. Japan's releases go direct to refiners, invisible for cargo trackers
- US draws hit a record 1.4 mb/d in mid-May. However, DOE has warned lift rates will degrade as inventory falls; expect moderation to 0.7-1.2 mb/d through August.
- SPR draws are set to drop from 2.5 mb /d in June to ~0.7 mb/d in July. A 5th US tranche or second IEA release would be needed to soften this

Exhibit 1: Global SPR releases are running at 2.5 mb/d during Apr-Jun, but are set to fall sharply to 0.7 mb/d in July and August



How Much has been Released? What Comes Next?

Strategic petroleum reserves around the world are being drawn down at the fastest pace on record in recent weeks. However, information on SPR releases is dispersed, especially outside the US. This can make the global trends hard to track. This note pulls it together.

The headline

~400-426 mb announced; ~150 mb of strategic stocks physically released so far. The IEA's initial 11 March announcement totalled 400 mb of stock releases, expanded to a 426 mb total contribution package in the official country contribution table published on 19 March. The higher figure includes some production-increase commitments from Canada and Mexico, so it is not purely an SPR draw. Country-level strategic releases that Argus and Platts have specifically documented sum to ~350 mb.

Roughly 150 mb of strategic stocks have been physically released through 25 May, putting the daily delivery rate at ~2.3 mb/d. Worth noting however that the 150 mb figure is a tracker of confirmed strategic draws. Several European countries have announced plans to release SPRs that have seen little-to-no observable follow-through in public newsflow so far. Therefore, it is possible that our tracker understates the true total by 20-40 mb. That may also explain the difference with the slightly higher figure of 2.5-3 mb/d which IEA executive director Birol recently mentioned.

Exhibit 2: 400 - 426 mb of SPR releases have been announced since mid-March

Strategic Petroleum Reserve releases

By country, as of 27 May 2026

Country	Volume	Type	Delivery window
Confirmed / underway			
United States (contracts awarded)	132.9 mb	Crude	20 Mar - 11 May; lifts Apr-Aug
United States (physical SPR drawdown, DOE)	50.3 mb	Crude	20 Mar - 22 May; 1.4 mb/d latest
Japan (national + joint, Phase 1 + 2)	~99 mb cumulative (79.8 mb in IEA table)	Crude	Phase 1: 26 Mar+; Phase 2: 1 May+
South Korea - IEA-coordinated release	22.5 mb (essentially complete)	Crude	From 11 Mar
South Korea - KNOC swap programme	~8 mb delivered (separate mechanism)	Crude	Swaps from Apr
Spain	3.75 mb of 11.55 mb authorised	Products	Mar-Apr (1st); balance by ~15 Jun
India (unilateral, outside IEA programme)	3 mb	Crude	Drawn by 17 Apr
Hungary (unilateral, outside IEA programme)	~3.6 mb (May) + Mar release (vol. n/a)	Products	10 Mar + 15 May
Baltic States	~1.1 mb	Mixed	Released 18 Mar
Austria	0.41 mb	Crude	OMV lift, 20 Apr
Announced / authorised, physical lifts unconfirmed			
Canada	23.6 mb (mostly production increase)	Crude (prod.)	TBD
Germany	19.5 mb announced	68% products	TBD
France	14.6 mb (IEA table)	Products	TBD
United Kingdom	14.0 mb govt-confirmed	Mostly products	Pace not disclosed
Turkiye	11.7 mb	Stock	TBD
Italy	10 mb authorised	Mixed	Window 1 Apr-30 Jun
Poland	7.5 mb	Stock	TBD
Netherlands	5.4 mb	Stock	TBD
Australia	4.8 mb announced	Mixed	TBD
Mexico	3.9 mb (production increase)	Crude (prod.)	TBD
China	None authorised	-	No reserve release

Sources: Platts, Argus, DOE/EIA Weekly Petroleum Status Report, Morgan Stanley Research

Who is doing what

The programme is overwhelmingly dominated by two countries. The United States has contracted 132.9 mb of its authorised 172 mb and has physically released 50.3 mb to date. Japan's contribution to the original IEA contribution table was 79.8 mb; the cumulative committed releases including the Phase 2 announcement of 10 April (which post-dates the IEA table) reach ~99 mb, of which roughly 50-55 mb has already moved. South Korea's IEA-coordinated release was 22.5 mb (essentially complete), and a separate KNOC-managed swap programme has lent refiners ~8 mb of additional crude on a borrow-and-return basis. The remaining contributors — Germany, UK, France, Italy, Spain, Hungary, Australia, India, Austria and the Baltic States, plus IEA members we don't track separately in this note (Canada, Türkiye, Poland, Netherlands, Mexico) — have combined commitments of ~135 mb but only a small fraction has confirmed physical lifts.

Two observations the headline numbers obscure:

Japan's contribution is nearly equal to the US's. In gross volume terms, Japan's ~99 mb commitment compares to the US's 132.9 mb contracted, and through May the two countries have each released roughly 50 mb. The Japan programme is often under-credited in public commentary because Japan barrels go directly to four named domestic refiners (ENEOS, Idemitsu, Cosmo Oil, Taiyo Oil) and are invisible to cargo-data trackers. US barrels, by contrast, flow to commodity traders and re-export as physical cargoes (~400 kb/d to Europe in May-June).

The "announced but not yet delivered" group is sizeable. Germany (19.4 mb), UK (14), France (14.6), Italy (10), Australia (4.8) — combined ~63 mb — have made commitments but produced no physical-lift confirmations in recent news coverage.

US in detail: contracted vs lifted

The US runs an exchange-contract programme — borrowers take crude now and return a minimum 17-26% extra by 2027-2029; realised premiums on Tranche 4 awards have been higher, at around 28%. Four tranches awarded so far:

Exhibit 3: US SPR: Four tranches have been awarded so far

US SPR exchange contracts: tranche detail

Four awarded tranches under Trump's 172 mb authorisation, as of 27 May 2026

Tranche	Award date	Offered (mb)	Awarded (mb)	Subscription	Crude type	SPR site(s)	Lift window	In-kind return premium
T1	20 Mar 2026	45.2	45.2	100%	Sweet + sour	Multiple	Apr - May 2026	+20%, repaid by end-2027
T2	10 Apr 2026	10.0	8.5	85%	Sour	Bryan Mound	Apr - May 2026	>=17%, repaid by 2027
T3	17 Apr 2026	30.0	26.0	87%	Sweet	West Hackberry	May - Jun 2026 (10/20)	>=18.5% if Q1 2028, +0.5pp/quarter
T4	11 May 2026	92.5	53.2	58%	Sweet + sour	Multiple	Jun - Aug 2026	>=18% by early 2027; up to 26.6% by Jul 2029

Sources: Argus, Platts, US Department of Energy RFPs, Morgan Stanley Research

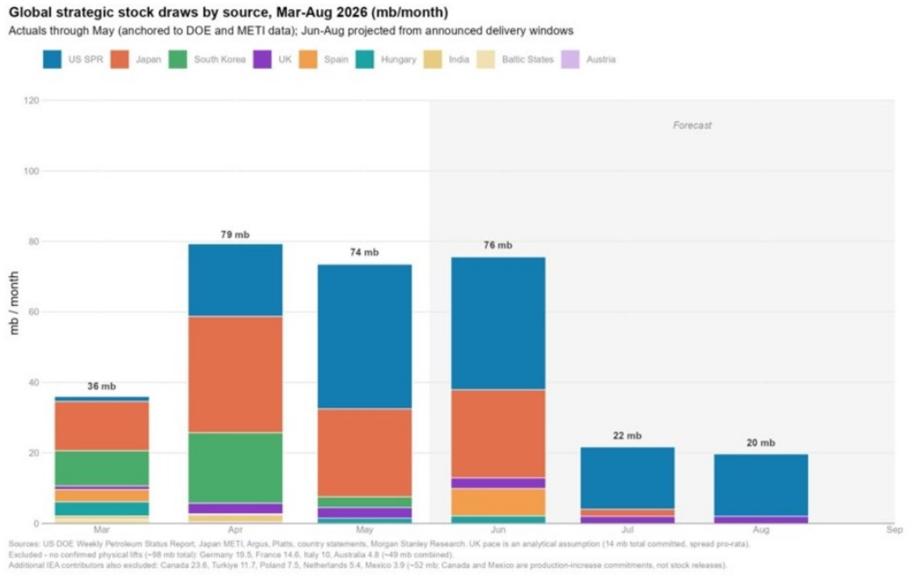
Exhibit 4: The pace of US SPR releases is tracking close to the schedule implied by the first four tranches

The gap between 132.9 mb contracted and 50.3 mb lifted is mostly due to timing, not execution. Actual lifts are within 5 mb (8%) of the contractually-scheduled pace. The analytically interesting development is **the 58% subscription rate on tranche 4** — vs essentially full subscriptions on tranches 1-3. That means filling the remaining 39 mb of Trump's 172 mb pledge requires either a fifth tender or a re-offer of T4's unsold 39 mb of inventory.

Forward profile: the July cliff

Tracked monthly draws hold at 75-80 mb in April-June, then drop to ~22 mb in July and ~20 mb in August. Japan Phase 2 ends in early July (PM Takaichi declined to authorise a third national release in May, citing sufficient crude secured for June; he did not categorically rule out a future Phase 3); Korea's IEA share is done; Spain delivers its 7.8 mb balance by mid-June; Hungary's second release expires 30 June. After that, only US T4 keeps running, at ~18 mb/month.

Exhibit 5: Tracked SPR releases average ~2.5 mb/d during April, May and June, but on current plans, drop off sharply in July



Two issues worth addressing directly

Can the US SPR sustain 1.4 mb/d?

Probably not for long. DOE explicitly warned in the T4 RFP that *"as SPR inventory is depleted, rates into the terminals will degrade."* SPR crude is stored in salt caverns and withdrawn by injecting water to displace it; at lower fill levels, the deliverable pumping rate falls. For context, the 2022 release peaked at ~1.0 mb/d when the US SPR held ~600 mb. The current 1.4 mb/d pace is at 365 mb — the system is being run harder at much lower inventory. **Realistic expectation: lift rate moderates to ~1.0-1.2 mb/d in June-July and ~0.7-0.9 mb/d in August** as inventory falls toward 285 mb. That would push 5-15 mb of T4 deliveries past the August deadline into September.

Is the July cliff hard or soft?

It depends on three specific factors: The schedule-driven step-down from ~76 mb in June to ~22 mb in July is largely locked in by the announced programmes ending. What could backfill it:

1. **A US tranche 5 announced by mid-June.** The probability of this is only moderate, we would argue, and likely conditional on the Hormuz situation persisting; a peace agreement would probably mean this won't go ahead.

2. **An IEA second coordinated release.** The probability of this is likely low. IEA Executive Director Dr Birol said on 21 May that the IEA is "discussing all the time", but member governments need to agree.

3. **The untracked countries (Germany, France, Italy, Australia and the additional IEA contributors) actually delivering.** Several countries announced plans to release SPR but have not seen much follow-through since. It could be the case that these releases come

through in the end. That could also make the July cliff genuinely softer.

If none of these materialise, July-August are down to ~20 mb/month — roughly a 60 mb/month step-down from Q2 pace. If two or three materialise, the programme continues at 40-60 mb/month through Q3.

What we are watching

The single most informative signal in the next 30 days is whether DOE announces a fifth tranche before mid-June. After that: US weekly lift rate, Spain's June delivery, any METI commentary on Phase 3.

Exhibit 6:

SPR Phase-2 watch list

Specific forward signals to monitor through Q3 2026 - as of 27 May 2026

Priority	Event / signal	Window	Confirmation tells us	Silence tells us
High	US T5 (5th tranche) RFP	Jun - early Jul	Administration is still chasing the 172 mb pledge; ~40 mb more sour/sweet to come	Demand exhausted; de facto cap at 132.9 mb
High	US T4 lift rate vs 800 kb/d (Jun-Aug)	Weekly (DOE Wed data)	If holds above 800 kb/d, cavern degradation warning was conservative	If drops below, deliveries slip past August; T5 even less likely
High	Japan Phase 3 announcement	Open (Takaichi said no on 12 May)	Reversal of policy; another ~30-40 mb of supply	Japanese commitment caps at ~99 mb regardless of Hormuz status
High	Spain balance release (7.8 mb)	By ~15 Jun	European product release fully delivers as scheduled	Slippage signals operator/Cores reluctance to deplete further
Medium	Italy first physical lift confirmation	ASAP (window open since 1 Apr)	Italian 10 mb commitment is real	Authorisation may be largely paper
Medium	Korea KNOC swap, 2nd tranche	Anytime (~22 mb of refiner requests still pending)	Korean uptake expands beyond the initial 8 mb	Refiners satisfied with Murban / US substitutes
Medium	Japan private mandate cut extension beyond 15 Jun	By 15 Jun	Tokyo still under pressure; private stocks staying below 70 days	Refiners have rebuilt private stocks via alt-imports
Medium	UK release pace disclosure	Open	Allows us to validate the 14 mb pro-rata assumption	UK lifting remains opaque; pace stays an analytical guess
Low	IEA second coordinated release	Open (Birol: 'discussing all the time')	Doubling of the program; 200-400 mb of additional supply on tap	First 426 mb release remains the operative ceiling
Low	Hungary 3rd release	Open (2nd release runs to 30 Jun)	Ad-hoc European product action continuing	30 Jun expiry without follow-up = product situation stabilising in CEE

Sources: Argus, Platts, DOE/EIA, METI, Morgan Stanley Research

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